Customer discovery — interview record

FishTrackPro · Doha Prime Ventures Limited · RC 8674998

Three structured interviews with Nigerian fish farmers. Quotes are verbatim. Interviewer: Olufemi Dominic Fabian.

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1 · Oladipo — grow-out farmer, Abuja

Pain score: 5 / 5

Hypothesis tested

Farmers lose almost 30% of their stock because they cannot track farm operations and performance, which also leads to poor yields.

Current workflow

Uses notebooks to record farm operations. Relies on visual observation of fish activity to know when to change water or feed, and the smell of the water to judge when it needs changing. Uses drugs to prevent fish death during sudden disease outbreaks. Describes it as running on instinct from previous experience rather than verified data.

What the pain actually is

Managing water quality is very difficult, and yield depends primarily on it. Money spent trying to prevent losses — drugs, reactive measures — doesn't actually stop the losses; it is just the only available option.

Operational cost per kilogram of fish often exceeds market selling price, making it hard to find buyers who can afford his price. He actively wishes he could cut feed costs and reduce mortality, and is considering starting his own hatchery to cut costs elsewhere in the value chain.

Confirmed

Farming without real-time data on operations and performance directly causes losses and produces unverifiable records — reinforcing that this is not only a mortality problem but a **cost-to-market-price viability problem**.

Assumption disproved

I assumed farmers would downplay or hide losses when interviewed by a stranger, since most prior interviews had produced overly polished results. This interview showed genuine, detailed vulnerability instead.

In his words

> *"I wish there is something that can help me cut the cost of feed in production and also reduce mortality by managing my water or any alternative that works"*

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2 · Udo — hatchery operator, Akwa Ibom

Pain score: 4 / 5

Hypothesis tested

Farmers lose up to 70% of fry overnight during the first four weeks after hatching, due to changes in water quality and overfeeding.

Current workflow

After sourcing good broodstock and completing hatching, fry go into a pond with continuous water flow in and out to prevent pollution — without it, fry can die within 24 hours. When he cannot afford the continuous-flow setup, he uses drugs in the pond to keep fry from getting sick immediately, and manually changes the water once or twice daily for the first four weeks.

What the pain actually is

With continuous water flow plus manual test strips, losses run around **10%**. Without proper flow, losses reach **70% to almost total loss**. Even using drugs as a substitute he still loses **30–40%**, because drugs act only as an antibiotic — they neither treat nor monitor water quality.

He or his staff often stay up most of the night checking the fish, which consumes significant time. Financial loss at that stage is limited because little has been spent on feed, but it **disrupts supply consistency**.

Confirmed

Water quality is a factor that can wipe out an entire stock overnight. Real-time monitoring of it is mandatory, not optional.

Assumption disproved

I thought hatcheries only used drugs to prevent mortality. I never imagined they could be running a manual RAS — a recirculating aquaculture system — by hand.

In his words

> *"Mismanagement is something that occurs due to human error which leads to water pollution and*

> *mortality, from my experience it is inevitable and painful because we have to work so hard and spend so much time taking care of the fry, even have sleepless nights"*

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3 · Eniola — grow-out farmer, Abuja

Interviewed 1 September 2026

Pain score: 5 / 5

Hypothesis tested

Farmers are locked out of loan and funding opportunities because they lack verifiable farm data.

Current workflow

Uses notebooks and spreadsheets to track farm operations — primarily operational costs, sales and inventory.

What the pain actually is

Has been trying to access government loans for **three years** without success. **Had to abandon one of his farms and rent it out** to raise funds for his other farm. Has considered starting a poultry farm as an alternative path to funding. Cannot scale, because it is hard to track farm operations rigorously enough to prove creditworthiness.

Confirmed

The rigour of his own tracking signalled that automated, real-time tracking and farm intelligence is a major unmet need — validating the core hypothesis. Three years of failed funding and the abandonment of a farm show this is not a minor inconvenience but a **business-threatening constraint**.

Assumption disproved

I used to believe every farmer clearly understood that proven farm data was the key to unlocking loan and funding opportunities. Many do not make that connection at all.

In his words

> *"I have given up on getting loan r government funding, even when other farmers that look up to me call me i tell them i dont have a solution"*

What these three interviews establish

The pattern that repeats across all three

Every farmer is already paying for a substitute that does not work.

- Oladipo buys drugs for sudden outbreaks, and says plainly that the money "doesn't actually stop the losses — it's just the only available option"
- Udo uses drugs when he cannot afford continuous flow, and still loses 30–40%, because "drugs only act as an antibiotic — they don't treat or monitor water quality"
- Both describe water as the thing that decides the outcome, and neither can see it

This matters commercially. These farmers are **not being asked to start spending** — they are being asked to spend differently. The budget already exists; it is currently going to antibiotics that treat a symptom after the fact.

The reframe from Oladipo

> *Operational cost per kilogram often exceeds market selling price.*

This is bigger than mortality. A farm losing 30% of stock is not merely producing less — it is producing at a unit cost the market will not pay. That turns FishTrackPro from *"save some fish"* into *"make the arithmetic work at all"*, and it is a sharper argument than the one currently in our materials.

Eniola is the financial-inclusion case, with a name

Three years of failed loan applications. A farm abandoned and rented out to fund the other one. And the line that should end any discussion of whether verifiable records matter:

> *"even when other farmers that look up to me call me i tell them i dont have a solution"*

He is the farmer other farmers ask for help, and he has none to give. That is worth more in a room than the statistic that 78% of rural smallholders are financially excluded, because a statistic describes a population and Eniola describes a Tuesday.

A second customer segment we had not costed: hatcheries

Udo is not our current target profile. His economics are different — low feed spend at fry stage, so the financial loss is modest — but the **operational** pain is severe: 70% loss overnight, and staff awake all night watching fish.

Two things follow. A hatchery already runs continuous-flow systems, so it is technically readier for sensors than a grow-out farm. And hatcheries sit upstream of every grow-out farmer in the country, which makes them a distribution channel as well as a customer.

Worth a deliberate decision rather than drift: is the hatchery a second segment, or a channel into the first?

What this changes in our materials

Where	Change
Problem statement	Lead with cost-per-kilo exceeding market price, not only mortality
Financial inclusion	Replace or support the 78% figure with Eniola's three years and abandoned farm
Competition	"Farmers already pay for drugs that do not work" is a stronger wedge than "nobody built this for catfish"
Market	Decide whether hatcheries are a segment or a channel
Validation evidence	Three structured interviews with pain scores, quotes, and disproved assumptions

What is still missing

These three are the deepest interviews we have, but they are three. The traction funnel records **25 farmers interviewed, 15 who tested, 8 who paid** — and we still cannot say why the seven who tested did not pay. That remains the sharpest unanswered question about our own customers, and three good interviews do not replace it.